SERVICE AT A CLICK

The e-governance revolution has reduced the digital divide between rural and urban India, and made government services readily accessible to citizens

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**

THE DRUDGERY

Citizen-government interactions in India—whether for payment of government fees/ taxes/ duties, procurement of documents or registering for welfare schemes—had for decades been characterised by inefficiency, lack of transparency and poor accessibility. Heavily dependent on manual processes, citizens faced challenges in availing of government services. There were also endless delays, marked by multiple rounds to government offices, as files inched from desk to desk. Corruption, too, would rear its ugly head all too often. The lack of integration among government departments further hampered service delivery. Awareness about schemes and services remained limited. The outcome? Enormous loss of time and productivity.

THE EASE OF LIVING

The gradual adoption of electronic governance, or e-governance, built on new infotech tools and aided by a digitalised bank of pre-existing data, is changing all that. In urban and, increasingly, in rural India, the services landscape has embraced technology in transformative ways to deliver citizen-centric solutions. The Digital India initiative, launched in 2015, is helping bridge the digital divide between rural and urban India and helped e-governance. Other than the 600,000 villages digitally connected through Common Service Centres that help reach government services to the common Indian, BharatNet has covered about 80 per cent of India's 264,000-plus gram panchayats with the infrastructure for high-speed internet. The unerring trackability of Aadhaar numbers is the last crucial piece of the jigsaw as India finally begins to solve the riddle of governance.

NATIONAL E-GOVERNANCE PLAN
Launched: ***May 2006, comprising 27 Mission Mode projects***

Achievement: 600,000 villages digitally linked through Common Service Centres

One of the standout achievements is the Online Building Permission System (OBPS). This single-window platform has streamlined the procurement of building permits. Earlier, applicants had to navigate a labyrinth of approvals by visiting multiple agencies. In cities like Delhi and Mumbai, the system has brought all relevant departments—fire safety, water supply, electricity boards—under one digital roof. Currently, over 2,530 urban local bodies have replicated this model. Similarly, paying municipal taxes and

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"Online building permission has increased transparency"

Vikas Gupta has recently reconstructed his ancestral house in Delhi. He had heard lurid stories of the cumbersome process people endured to get permission from civic agencies before he learned about the Online Building Permission System (OBPS) launched by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) in 2019. Gupta visited the OBPS website, created an account, filled out the application form, uploaded the documents and paid the fees. The system verified his application and documents, and he received an acknowledgement receipt. Within 10 days, Gupta received an email stating that his building permit had been approved. He downloaded the permit from the OBPS website and began construction. "OBPS has trans-